

chooses its 1,500 MW plants. Says Ron Somers, president of the US India Business Council, "We are looking at \$150 billion of business in the nuclear industry alone." Canada, which angrily cut off its nuclear agreement with India after the 1974 test, is talking about restarting trade. "It's a good feeling," says an Indian negotiator.

Meanwhile, with fuel now expected, India is expanding its own indigenous capacity. It has just mastered the 700 MW type of reactors and is building four of them within the next five years. It is also perfecting its Fast Breeder Reactors (FBRs), so called because they generate as much plutonium as they consume. This, if successful, will give a major boost to power generation plans. Under the deal, India is creating a National Technical Facility to store spent

event of an accident to ensure that all leaks would be contained and there would be no need for evacuation. With so many reactors being built and run at a short time, India needs to beef up its regulatory board and safety standards.

On the strategic side, the big question is what happens if India tests a nuclear weapon? Under its deal with India, the US would terminate the agreement and could even demand the return of reactors and fuel supplied by it. But while negotiating the agreement, the Indian side pushed the Americans to soften the whole breakaway clause by ensuring no sudden deaths or withdrawals. There would be a protracted negotiation and the circumstances that led India to test would become a factor. This would mean that if say China and Pakistan tested, India

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INKED: Kakodkar and Kouchner sign the Indo-French nuke cooperation agreement

fuel from its reactors it designates as civilian. With permission to reprocess such fuel, the spent plutonium could be used as fuel in FBRs. That would put India streets ahead in the business. Its also on its way to using abundant thorium reserves as a fuel. Most importantly, India will be allowed to export its own reactors, especially in the market for smaller reactors of 220 MW and 540 MW.

The downsides: Issues like the safety of reactors are a major concern. The world nuclear industry has strived hard to make their plants almost error free and in the

would have good enough reasons to test. The US President would then have waiver power to prevent the provisions of the Act from being enforced.

Learning from the Tarapur experience, where the US reneged from the agreement to supply fuel to it after the 1974 tests, India will insist that all the vendors give cast-iron guarantees of fuel supply and the country would maintain a strategic reserve of fuel to meet such exigencies. So the right to test remains with India but as Mukherjee told INDIA TODAY, "Other nations have the right to react." Exasperated by the constant nagging over whether we can test or not, a senior official said, "Look, it's like asking a woman to prove her virginity. She can only do it by losing it." And if Barack Obama comes to power and he gets the US to ratify the CTBT, India could be pressured into signing the document. Right now India and Pakistan are the main holdouts.

So would it crimp India's weapons programme as the Opposition has been charging?

Under the deal, India has so far identified eight reactors that it would designate as military—four at Kalpakkam near Chennai, two at Kaiga in Karnataka and two at Tarapur. It also has two research reactors Dhruva and Cirrus. (Cirrus is to be decommissioned in 2010). These would provide as much fissile material as India needs for its credible minimum deterrent. Since India would be allowed to import fuel, it can conserve its domestic mines to build bombs. While India has agreed to join negotiations for a Fissile Material Cut Off Treaty, it is unlikely to sign till it is satisfied that it has a large enough stockpile.

India is pressing ahead with its triad of missiles, aircraft and nuclear power submarines to deliver its weapons (*see chart*). Those programmes are proceeding at full speed. Agni, with its many variants, can now threaten most of China's major cities apart from the whole of Pakistan. India's top secret nuclear submarine is on its way to completion, giving it the ability to strike from the sea. And it is building a state-of-the-art anti-ballistic missiles system. On all these programmes, the deal allows India to proceed at a fair trot without hindrance. In some areas like missiles, it could even collaborate and get the much-needed high technology for them.

More importantly is the deal's impact on India's self-confidence and its image abroad. India is clearly recognised as a power that has arrived on the world stage. It can shed its baggage of non-alignment and go for what Lalit Mansingh, former foreign secretary, calls co-alignments with all the major countries whether the US, Russia, France, China, South Africa, Brazil, the UK, Australia. India has already entered into strategic partnerships with all of them. It can push for a seat in the UN Security Council now with greater vigour. A new world has opened for India. It's up to us to go out and make the best use of the opportunity. ■